He said he was more concerned about the release of *Dr Bezbaruah 2*. The episode ended with Shah Rukh calling Sarma at 2 am and the latter assuring him that "no such untoward incident" would happen.

Such public posturing has made Sarma a poster boy for Hindutva followers across India. He is the first politician from the Northeast to get regular invites from BJP state units to campaign for them. And he obliges them with comments that are bound to polarise voters. "In my constituency, he raised the issue of 'love jihad', which contributed to my victory," says Kaushikbhai Jain, a BJP MLA in Gujarat. Sarma had labelled the infamous Shraddha Walker murder a case of 'love jihad' (the accused is a Muslim). In Telangana, he thundered that AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi's name will be wiped out like the Nizams; In Uttarakhand, he hit below the belt: "Have we ever asked who Rahul Gandhi's father is?"

THE ADMINISTRATOR

Back home, Sarma's administration has been a mix of long-term reforms and shock and awe tactics. Apart from making governance transparent with the help of digital technology, one of his top priorities has been land reforms. The Assam government's flagship Mission Bashundhara aims to regularise and digitise all land records, a much-needed step in a state where 6,652 sq. km of public land and 22 per cent or 3,878.8 sq. km of total forest land is under encroachment.

True to his style, Sarma launched the mission with good optics: in September 2021, 453 land brokers were arrested in just one day after raids, much like the sudden police action against child marriages. During the launch of the second phase in November 2022, Sarma minced no words when he said the objective was to provide and regularise land rights for indigenous people. The intent was evident at the launch of the mission. The CM had special instructions for deputy commissioners of certain districts—Dhubri, Barpeta, Goalpara, Morigaon and Nagaon—that they be extremely careful in regularising villages on government land. These districts are among the nine in Assam where Muslims are in a majority.

That said, transparency and delivery of services have been the trademarks of the Sarma model of governance. All cabinet decisions are immediately made public, with Sarma personally tweeting them. In the past two years, he has held half a dozen conferences with deputy commissioners (DCs) and superintendents of police (SPs) in the districts and the resolutions of these meetings have also been made public.

The CM also seeks to separate the administration from his political grandstanding. In his interactions with DCs and SPs, he categorically asks them to follow direct written or verbal instructions and not to go by his political statements. So, despite his feigning ignorance about Shah Rukh, he ensured there was enough security at cinema halls playing *Pathaan* after the Bajrang Dal incident. "This is a golden time for us, as we can do what police officers often dream of doing. There is no political interference, and every instruction is thorough and legal," says DGP Singh.

Even with Mission Bashundhara, no Muslim with valid documents has faced difficulty in regularising his/ her land rights. Indeed, Prabajan Virodhi Manch (PVM), an organisation raising the issue of illegal immigration, has alleged that with the mission the Sarma government has allotted over 450,000 acres land to landless immigrant families who came to Assam before 2011. In recent times, indigenous Assamese too have borne the brunt of his eviction drives. On February 27, 300 Assamese families were evicted from government land in Guwahati and two temples were demolished.

Sarma's aides also point to how some of his interventions have been crucial in justice being delivered. Naba Patgiri, OSD (communication, PR and protocol) to the CM, recounts a small news item on the 'suicide' of a minor tribal girl Sarma noticed. Working as a domestic help in Dhula in Darrang district, the girl was found hanging her employer Krishna Kamal Baruah's house last June. Though the police concluded it as a case of suicide, her family cried murder. Sarma asked the SP to file a report, which he found unsatisfactory. "He read the report at 2 am and seven hours later, he headed to the deceased girl's home," says Patgiri. Following the CM's visit, the investigation turned on its head and resulted in the arrest of the accused along with three police officers, including the SP, one executive magistrate and three doctors for trying to shield the accused.

It's this attention to micro details and the ability to understand the public pulse that have helped Sarma retain their attention. He is also displaying this skill on a much larger canvas now, with the rest of the country waking up to a political paradigm Assam has been witness to for more than three decades. ■



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G.P. SINGH
DGP, Assam Police



"When a leader like Himanta comes for campaigning, we can see the effect on the people. In my constituency, he raised the issue of love jihad, which contributed to my victory"

KAUSHIKBHAI JAIN
BJP MLA, Gujarat